

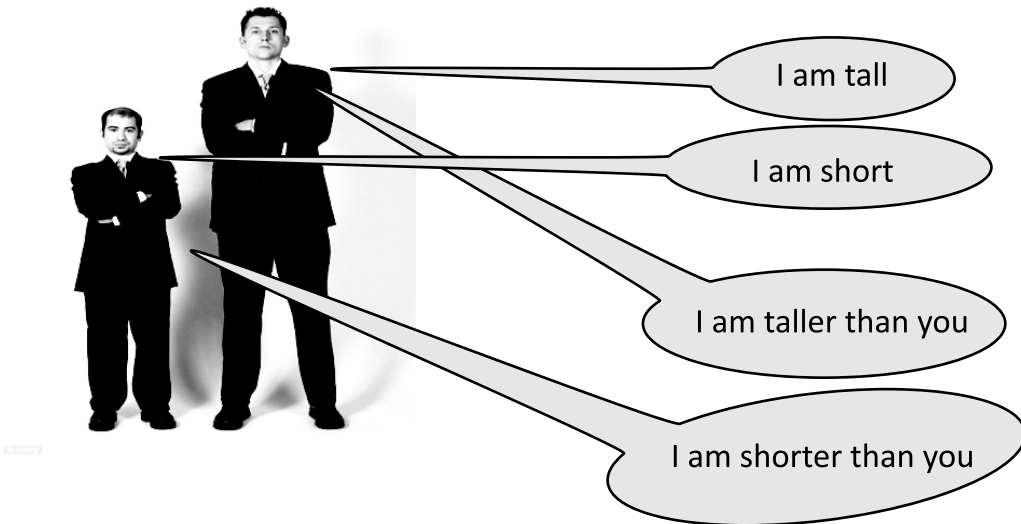
UNIT

4

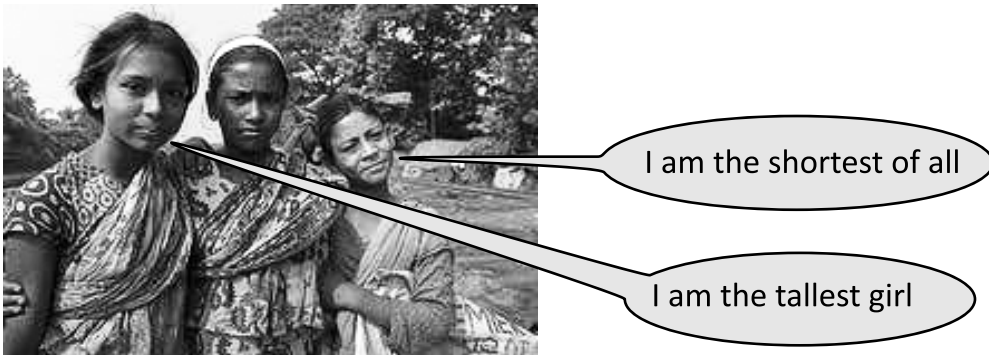
Degrees of Adjectives

Lesson 1: Introducing Degrees

Look at the picture and read the dialogue:



The words 'short' and 'tall' qualify the two persons. These two qualifying words tell us one of the men is tall and the other is short. On the other hand, the other forms of the words, 'taller' and 'shorter' compare their height. The words 'short', 'tall' are called adjectives. Different forms of these adjectives are used to compare two or more things or to compare their qualities. Look at the following picture and sentences to see comparison between more than two things or their qualities.



Now, underline the different forms of the qualifying words used in the bubbles above. Then discuss the following questions with your classmates:

1. What are the different forms of the words 'short' and 'tall'?
2. What forms of the words have been used to compare two persons?
3. What forms of the words have been used to compare three or more persons or things?

Remember that, the base form of the words 'short' and 'tall' is called **positive degree** or **positive degree of adjectives**. When they are used to compare between two, the base words become 'shorter' and 'taller' respectively. This form of adjectives is called **comparative degree**. If we compare between three or more, the base forms change to 'shortest' and 'tallest' respectively and this form of the adjectives is **superlative degree**.

Formation of Comparatives and Superlatives

- i) Adjectives of one syllable take 'er' to form comparatives and 'est'/'st' to form their superlative degrees.

Now, work in pairs and try to make the comparative and superlative forms of the following adjectives:

big, small, fast, slow, wise

Read the following list individually first and then discuss the adjectives and their comparative and superlative forms with your partners:

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
tall	taller	tallest
short	shorter	shortest
small	smaller	smallest
fast	faster	fastest
slow	slower	slowest

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
black	blacker	blackest
bright	brighter	brightest
cheap	cheaper	cheapest
close	closer	closest
cold	colder	coldest
cool	cooler	coolest
deep	deeper	deepest
few	fewer	fewest
fine	finer	finest
great	greater	greatest
high	higher	highest
large	larger	largest
long	longer	longest
low	lower	lowest
new	newer	newest
noble	nobler	noblest
poor	poorer	poorest
quick	quicker	quickest
rich	richer	richest
safe	safer	safest
short	shorter	shortest
simple	simpler	simplest

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
soft	softer	softest
strong	stronger	strongest
sweet	sweeter	sweetest
thick	thicker	thickest
weak	weaker	weakest
young	younger	youngest

Now, practise the following conversation with your partner. Change your role while practising. After the first round of practice, use your own names and your own qualities:

Alim : Sarwar, you are short.

Sarwar : Probably I am not shorter than you.

Alim : Sorry Sarwar, I am taller than you.

Sarwar : But you are not the tallest student in the class.

Alim : I agree, Riad is the tallest boy in our class. Who is the shortest student in our class?

Sarwar : I am sure, it is not me. Probably Raihana is the shortest student in our class.

Alim : Sarwar, we should not label one as *tall, taller, tallest* or, *short, shorter, shortest* without measuring their heights.

Sarwar : You are quite right, Alim.

ii) If a one syllable adjective ends in a vowel followed by a consonant, the consonant becomes double when any suffix (er, est) is added. If there are two vowels before the last consonant of the adjective, the last consonant will not be doubled (*sweet, sweeter, sweetest*). Read the adjectives from the following table and notice their comparative and superlative forms:

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
big	bigger	biggest
fat	fatter	fattest
fit	fitter	fittest
glad	gladder	gladdest
hot	hotter	hottest
red	redder	reddest
sad	sadder	saddest
thin	thinner	thinnest

Lesson 2: More about degree

Read the following positive, comparative and superlative forms of adjectives. Discuss with your partner how they are different from the previous ones.

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
busy	busier	busiest
dirty	dirtier	dirtiest
dry	drier	driest
easy	easier	easiest
happy	happier	happiest
healthy	healthier	healthiest
heavy	heavier	heaviest
hungry	hungrier	hungriest
lovely	lovelier	loveliest
ugly	uglier	ugliest

Note: If one syllable adjectives end in consonant followed by 'y', 'y' is changed into 'i' and 'er/est' is added to comparative and superlative forms. Remember that, if the last 'y' is preceded by a vowel, the 'y' remains unchanged and 'er', 'est' are used to make comparative and superlative forms respectively. For instance, *grey, greyer, greyest*.

Now, read the positive, comparative, and superlative forms of adjectives from the list below and discuss with your friends how the positive forms of the adjectives have been changed into comparative and superlative.

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
active	more active	most active
attentive	more attentive	most attentive
beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful
careful	more careful	most careful
comfortable	more comfortable	most comfortable
difficult	more difficult	most difficult
famous	more famous	most famous
generous	more generous	most generous
interesting	more interesting	most interesting
obedient	more obedient	most obedient

Note: Comparatives and superlatives of adjectives made of more than two syllables are made adding 'more' and 'most' before the adjectives respectively.

Now, read the following list of adjectives and look at the comparative and superlative forms of them:

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
bad	worse	worst
far	farther	farthest
fore	former	foremost
good	better	best
late	later/latter	latest/last
little	less	least
many/much	more	most
old	older/elder	oldest/eldest
out	outer	outmost
up	upper	upmost/uppermost

Exercise 1

Now, read the weather forecast and underline the adjectives. Write all the three forms (positive, comparative, and superlative) of all the adjectives you find in the forecast. Then compare your answers with your partners.

Weather is likely to remain dry with cloudy sky over the country. Mild cold wave is sweeping over the regions of Madaripur, Rajshahi, Pabna, Sayedpur, Jashore, Kushtia and Srimangal, and it may continue and spread elsewhere over Rangpur division. Moderate to thick fog may occur over the river basins and light to moderate fog elsewhere over the country during midnight till morning. Night temperature may fall slightly over Rangpur division and it may remain nearly unchanged elsewhere over the country. However, between late December and early January, coldest weather in the last five years is predicted. After some good winters since 2010, we may feel the biting of winter. In that period of time, temperature may be less than 10 degrees Celsius in a few places. Poor and elderly people, and little babies may suffer more for want of warm clothes.

(adapted)

Read the following sentences to experience how to transform sentences containing the degrees of comparison to each other:

A) Positive to comparative

- i) Positive: Faridul is as tall as Riad
Comparative: Riad is not taller than Faridul.
- ii) Positive: Khorshed is as handsome as Subrato.
Comparative: Subrato is not more handsome than Khorshed.

B) Comparative to superlative

- i) Comparative: My father is older than any other man in the village.
Superlative: My father is the oldest man in the village.
- ii) Comparative: Milk is more nutritious than any other drink.
Superlative: Milk is the most nutritious drink.

C) Superlative to positive

- i) Superlative: Atanu is the best boy in class eight.
Positive: No other boy in class eight is as good as Atanu.
- ii) Superlative: Shamsur Rahman is the most famous modern poet of Bangladesh.
Positive: No other modern poet of Bangladesh is so famous as Shamsur Rahman.
- iii) Superlative: Sraboni is one of the most intelligent girls in the class.
Positive: Very few girls in the class are as intelligent as Sraboni.

D) Interchange of Degrees

- i) Positive: Very few airlines are as good as Apollo Airlines.
Comparative: Apollo Airlines is better than most other airlines.
Superlative: Apollo Airlines is one of the best airlines.
- ii) Positive: No other man in the locality is so active as Mr. Anwar.
Comparative: Mr. Anwar is more active than any other man in the locality.
Superlative: Mr Anwar is the most active man in the locality.

Note: Superlative degrees always take definite article before them. For instance: the **best** boy; the **greatest** dramatist; the **most handsome** man; and the **happiest** man.

Exercise 2

Fill in the gaps with appropriate forms of adjectives given in the parenthesis:

I met a _____ (tall) man on the way to school. Of course, he was not _____ (tall) than our head teacher. Our head teacher is the _____ (tall) man in the village. He is not only the tallest but also the _____ (handsome) and the _____ (wise) man in the area.

Exercise 3

Fill in the following conversation with appropriate forms of adjectives. Use different degrees of the adjective – *cold* and *warm*:

Shishir: It's so _____ today, isn't it? Swapan: Of course. It's _____ than yesterday, I am sure.

Shishir: How do you know yesterday was _____

Swapan: People were trying to protect themselves with _____ clothes.

Shishir: But the weather forecast is that, the next few days will be _____

Swapan: Lovely!

Transform the following sentences as directed in the brackets:

i) Mr Bashar is the busiest man in the school. (positive)

ii) No other dramatist in the world is so great as William Shakespeare. (superlative)

iii) Sadia is as beautiful as Papia. (comparative)

iv) No other singer in Bangladesh was so popular as Basir Ahamed during the 70s. (superlative)

Mercury is one of the softest metals in the world. (positive)